

off a computer screen for that matter. However, Microsoft claims to have come up with a display technology that lends the look and feel of high resolution printing to onscreen reading.

Called Clear Type, this technology provides you with crisp and easy-to-read text on your screen, be it a laptop, PDA or any other specialised reader. Another prototype device being developed by a core group consisting of Toshiba, NTT Data and E-book Initiative, Japan, to address this problem consists of two vertically attached LCD panels with a high-resolution screen.

More than mere books

Technology isn't only about creating innovations, but about coming up with innovative solutions that help towards achieving the most important of goals—helping people. eBooks wouldn't be as big an achievement if those that are visually impaired couldn't also enjoy them.

Microsoft and Pulse Data International seem to have taken up the challenge by attempting to make Braille-ready eBook readers. The plan of action involves integrating the Microsoft Reader and Pulse Data's BrailleNote software, a family of screenless devices that translate text into speech and Braille.

A visually impaired individual could choose from downloading an e-book to be read on a Braille reader, or even listen to the speech version.

The National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) has developed a prototype that can translate text into Braille, and features variable speeds, allowing people to read faster or slower, or to pause the device. The reader can transform text into Braille and can also be used for reading e-mail, browsing the Web, and other text-based applications.

Flash in the pan?

Will e-books make it big in the future, or will they remain just a passing fad? It is too early to say. Since eBooks have emerged on the scene only recently, they are yet to catch up with the mainstream. As of now, the two major suppliers of e-books are Amazon and Barnes and Nobles, who provide you with access to eBooks at a price. While there are quite a few sites that allow you to download eBooks for free, there also exists the question of copyrights. But if you're looking to make your mark as a writer, then this is the perfect medium that should get you there. So what are you waiting for? Logon and start e-publishing your magnum opus. 

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